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Culture summary

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CULTURE SUMMARY: TIV

Paul Bohannon and Ian Skoggard

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Material Not Relevant

ETHNONYMS

Munchi, Munshi, Tivi.

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Identification

ORIENTATION

IDENTIFICATION AND LOCATION

The Tiv (sing., Or-Tiv) are a group of about a million people who live on both sides of the Benue River, 220 kilometers from its confluence with the Niger, in Nigeria. "Tiv" is the name of the common ancestor from whom all are descended. In Hausa they are called "Munshi" or "Munchi." The heartland of Tivland stretches from about 6 to 8 degrees latitude north and from 8 to 10 degrees longitude east, although Tiv settlements are also found north and east of that area. In the southeast, Tivland borders the foothills of the Cameroons, from whence the Tiv say they originally came. Some hills,

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Identification

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Location

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especially in southern Tivland, are as high as 1,200 meters. The undulating plains of tall grasses (as much as 3 meters high), dotted with savanna trees, lose elevation until they reach the Benue, at about 100 to 120 meters. The Tiv, who are an expanding people, are well along in their occupation of the similar plain that extends northward from the river toward the Jos Plateau.

Topography And
Geology

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Flora

DEMOGRAPHY

The earliest estimate of the Tiv population, in 1933, was 600,000. In 1950 the count was about 800,000. By 1990, the figure had climbed to more than a million. The density of population in Tivland in 1950 was about 166 per square kilometer, but that figure is misleading. In the southern area, where the Tiv reside adjacently with the small groups of peoples they know collectively as the Udam, the density rises to at least 1,430 per square kilometer.

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Population

LINGUISTIC AFFILIATION

There is a single Tiv language intelligible to all, although regional dialects allow one to distinguish the area from which a person comes. The language is classified as the only example of its subdivision (on the same level as Bantu languages) of the Niger-Congo Language Family.

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Linguistic
Identification

HISTORY AND CULTURAL RELATIONS

The Tiv say they emerged into their present location from the southeast. "Coming down," as they put it, they met the Fulani, with whom they still recognize a joking relationship. The earliest recorded European contact was in 1852, when Tiv were found on the banks of the Benue. In 1879 their occupation of the riverbanks was about the same as in 1950. British occupying forces entered Tivland from the east in 1906, when they were called in to protect a Hausa and Jukun enclave that Tiv had attacked. The Tiv said in 1950 that they had defeated this British force, then later invited the British in. The first British patrols of southern Tivland did not occur until 1911, which the southern Tiv refer to as the British "eruption." This year also marked the first arrival of Dutch Reformed missionaries from South Africa; they were joined, and then succeeded, by US Protestants in the 1940s and 1950s. Catholic missions arrived in the 1920s. The early administration, coming as it did from the east where Tiv had come under the influence (but not the hegemony) of Jukun and Hausa kingdoms, established "District Heads," who were influential men to whom the British gave authority in which other Tiv did not concur. That system was extended beyond the area of Jukun influence to other Tiv, causing disturbances. Beginning in 1934, the administration created Tiv experts--men who learned the Tiv language and stayed for far longer periods of time than most colonial officers stayed with any given people. Their reports provided a firm basis for administrative reform.

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